

TB Grain Phaser

Version: 2.0.0 | Documentation date: 2026-08-17

Overview

Carves a moving pattern of spectral gaps into a sound, creating grain-like texture without slicing, stretching, or repitching the performance.

What this plug-in solves

Static pads, guitar sustains, drum loops, and effects often need internal movement without becoming a conventional chorus, flanger, or granular sampler. TB Grain Phaser creates a dense repeating pattern of spectral gaps, moves that pattern, and can orbit the resulting texture across stereo. The original audio is not cut into samples, rearranged, time-stretched, or pitch-shifted.

What you can expect

- Broad dusty gaps or fine dense grain-like texture from the same source
- Static etching, gentle drift, focused travel, or wide experimental orbital motion
- A latency-aligned dry/wet blend that works on inserts and parallel sound-design layers
- A real Grain Chamber display, eleven factory starting points, and complete User preset recall

How it works

TB Grain Phaser examines short overlapping moments of the spectrum and applies a repeating pattern of gain gaps. Moving that pattern creates the impression of spectral grains, but the original performance is never cut into samples or rearranged.

GRAIN defines the pattern, MOVE travels through it, AMOUNT controls how clearly it is carved, and WIDTH spreads only the generated motion. A delayed direct path keeps MIX and BYPASS aligned with the spectral result.

Quick start

- 1** Insert the plug-in on a pad, guitar, drum bus, or sound-design layer and begin with Init or the closest Factory preset.
- 2** Set GRAIN first: move lower for fewer broad gaps or higher for a finer, denser texture.
- 3** Raise MOVE until the pattern travels with the desired sense of motion; use its neutral position for a static centered etch.
- 4** Raise AMOUNT until the grain contrast is clear, then reduce it if attacks become hollow or spread.
- 5** Add WIDTH after the texture works in the center. Use the upper part of the control only as an intentional experimental choice and check mono.
- 6** Blend MIX to keep the original performance in front or move it fully toward the designed texture.
- 7** Compare with BYPASS while DAW delay compensation is enabled, then save a User preset when the result works across the complete passage.

Interface and key sections



This is a direct capture of the current plug-in interface. Use the visible labels to locate the areas and controls explained below.

Spectral grains, not sliced samples

The plug-in looks at short overlapping moments of the spectrum and places a repeating pattern of level gaps across them. GRAIN changes how coarse or fine that pattern is, MOVE travels through it, AMOUNT changes its depth and energy, and WIDTH distributes the generated motion across stereo. Because the audio is not cut into time-domain grains, there is no sample slicing, grain pitch, reverse, or time-stretch control.

Grain Chamber

The LOW-to-HIGH display uses real input and processing telemetry. Bright phosphor-green Korean, Chinese, Japanese, and English glyphs show passing energy, while dim green glyphs show energy removed by the mask. Input energy controls occupancy and brightness; GRAIN sets how many glyph candidates each active band can show. Top-to-bottom travel follows the real mask phase, small horizontal offsets follow pan, glyph size follows depth, and faint upward echoes show the signed Side-phase cue. It is an activity view, not decorative Matrix rain, a pitch meter, or an autonomous animation.

How the four sound macros interact

GRAIN sets the size and spacing of the spectral pattern. MOVE develops both travel and generated spatial motion. AMOUNT supplies the audible contrast and motion energy; at its neutral position the wet engine becomes transparent. WIDTH controls only the stereo motion added by the plug-in and cannot create movement by itself when MOVE or AMOUNT is neutral. MIX then blends the aligned direct and processed paths.

Preset and history header

The header provides Previous, the current preset menu, Next, Save, Undo, and Redo. Previous and Next move through Factory presets and alphabetically sorted User presets, wrapping at the ends. The Factory set is Init, Soft Motion, Guitar Drift, Drum Scatter, Coarse Dust, Fine Grain, Static Etch, Pad Orbit, Focused Travel, Full Travel, and Doppler Rift. When the controls no longer match the selected preset, the name changes to MODIFIED.

User presets and session recall

User presets use the .tbgp extension and are saved in Documents/TB_GrainPhaser/Presets/User. A Factory or User recall is one Undo step. The selected User name and reference state return with the DAW session, and an invalid or wrong-product preset is rejected without partially changing the current sound.

Timing and supported signal paths

The spectral process uses a fixed processing delay, and the dry, wet, and bypass paths remain aligned. Keep DAW delay compensation enabled and use the effect primarily for production, mixing, and sound design rather than zero-latency live monitoring. The current build accepts matching mono or stereo input and output and does not use MIDI or sidechain audio.

Controllable properties

The guide uses the names shown on the plug-in panel. Each explanation describes the audible result, a useful way to approach the control, and an important interaction to listen for.

Control	What it does and when to use it
GRAIN	Changes the spectral grain pattern from broad and coarse toward tight and fine. It is not a time-domain grain length. Set it before the motion controls so the basic texture is useful while static.
MOVE	Develops mask travel, pattern shape, movement speed, and the generated spatial orbit. Raise it until the travel is clear without making the pattern compete with the performance.
WIDTH	Sets the reach of the stereo orbit and Side-phase motion added by the plug-in while preserving the original input stereo. Add it after MOVE and AMOUNT work in the center, then check mono before keeping an extreme setting.
AMOUNT	Sets spectral depth, edge contrast, and movement energy. Its neutral position makes the wet reconstruction transparent. Lower it first when attacks spread, the source becomes hollow, or too much energy disappears.
MIX	Blends the latency-aligned direct and spectral paths. Use a lower blend on drums and guitar when the direct attack should lead; use full wet for designed layers.
BYPASS	Returns the latency-aligned direct signal with a softened transition. Keep DAW delay compensation active and compare the same musical passage.

Practical uses

Subtle pad or drone motion

- Start with Soft Motion or Pad Orbit and play a sustained chord.
- Choose a medium-to-fine GRAIN setting so the texture feels connected rather than broken.
- Set MOVE slowly enough that the harmonic pattern evolves without sounding like a repeating tremolo.
- Use moderate WIDTH and MIX, then check the sustained chord in mono.

Expected result: A static pad develops a living internal drift while its notes and envelope remain recognizable.

Guitar sustain and release

- Begin with Guitar Drift and loop a phrase containing both pick attack and decay.
- Use GRAIN to separate the texture from the fundamental without thinning the complete note.
- Lower AMOUNT if the pick becomes smeared, then use MOVE to animate the sustain.
- Blend MIX so the processed release surrounds the direct attack.

Expected result: The guitar keeps its playing definition while the sustain gains spectral movement and space.

Parallel drum scatter

- Start with Drum Scatter on an insert or parallel return.
- Keep GRAIN coarse enough that the rhythm remains readable.
- Use strong MOVE with controlled AMOUNT, then lower MIX until the direct transients lead.
- Check kick and snare in mono before increasing WIDTH.

Expected result: The loop gains animated debris and motion around the hits without replacing the original punch.

Static etch and full-wet texture

- Choose Static Etch for a fixed pattern, or Coarse Dust and Fine Grain for full-wet design.
- Set GRAIN for the desired size of the spectral holes.
- Use AMOUNT to find the balance between recognizable source and designed surface.
- Keep MOVE neutral for a fixed imprint or raise it only after the static tone is useful.

Expected result: The source becomes a repeatable spectral material ranging from carved and hollow to dense and granular.

Teach and audition WIDTH

- Compare Focused Travel, Full Travel, and Doppler Rift to hear the same core movement progress from centered to intentionally extreme width.
- Choose the least extreme version that creates the needed space, then check mono and Side polarity.

Expected result: WIDTH becomes an audible spatial decision rather than an automatic request for maximum size.

Common pitfalls

If there is no motion, confirm BYPASS is off and both MOVE and AMOUNT are away from their neutral positions; WIDTH alone does not create movement.

If the source becomes too hollow or attacks smear, lower AMOUNT first and then reduce MIX.

If the stereo center weakens in mono, move WIDTH toward its reference or narrow end; the upper region is intentionally experimental.

A blank or still Grain Chamber after silence or host stop is expected because the display follows real input energy.

MIX and BYPASS are latency-aligned, but the fixed spectral delay is still felt during live monitoring even when the DAW aligns recorded tracks.

The plug-in is not a granular sampler and does not provide tempo sync, feedback, sidechain, pitch shifting, time stretching, or oversampling.

Strong AMOUNT can intentionally remove spectral energy and spread sharp transients; use a parallel blend when the original attack must lead.